

RENTORA

Verified Student Housing, Made Simple

PROJECT OVERVIEW

LAUTECH — Ogbomosho, Oyo State, Nigeria

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What Rentora Is

Rentora is a student housing platform built for LAUTECH (Ladoke Akintola University of Technology) students in Ogbomosho, Nigeria. It connects students searching for accommodation with verified local agents, and manages the entire journey in one place — discovery, contact, viewing, and payment — replacing the informal, word-of-mouth process most students currently rely on.

The platform is live in production and supports the full transaction lifecycle: listing and admin verification, free property viewings, and holding rent payments in escrow until a tenant confirms they've moved in. Every part of that lifecycle is designed around a single idea: money should only move when there is a real, verifiable action behind it — a genuine move-in, not on trust alone.

The Problem

- Off-campus student housing near LAUTECH is found almost entirely through word of mouth, campus flyers, and unverified agents — there is no central, trustworthy place to search.
- Students often pay agents or “middlemen” upfront with no way to confirm a property is real, available, or accurately described before money changes hands.
- Agents have no professional platform to list verified properties, manage viewings, or get paid reliably and transparently.
- There is no accountability layer — if a deal goes wrong, there is no record, no dispute process, and no trust mechanism protecting either side.

The Solution

Rentora replaces that informal process with a structured, trust-based platform where every actor — student, agent, and platform — has clear rules and protections.

- **Verified contact & viewings** — Students browse verified listings for free, with the agent's contact details visible directly on every listing — no unlock step required.
- **Free property viewings** — Students can request a viewing instead of visiting blind, at no cost. A verified agent conducts it in person, and the student can optionally tip the agent afterward for good service.
- **Rent escrow** — When a student pays rent through Rentora, the funds are held — not paid out — until the student confirms they've received the keys and moved in, then released to the agent's Rentora balance. If the student goes silent, funds auto-release after a configurable window so agents aren't left waiting indefinitely.
- **Verified agents & listings** — Agents must submit ID, a selfie, and bank details, and every listing goes through admin review before it appears publicly. Any edit to an already-approved listing automatically drops it back into the review queue.
- **“Mark as Taken”** — Once a student has moved in, the property is automatically marked unavailable so it stops appearing to other students — no stale, already-taken listings cluttering search.

How It Works

For Students

- Browse verified listings by price, location, and property type — no account required.
- View a listing's agent contact details directly, or request a free viewing to have an agent show the property in person first.
- Pay rent securely through Rentora, including the auto-calculated agent fee — the money is held until move-in is confirmed, never paid out during the hold.
- Confirm move-in from their profile — this releases the full held amount to the agent's balance and marks the property taken.

For Agents

- Apply for verification with ID, a selfie, and bank details; approval is reviewed by an admin.
- List properties with rent price and the property owner's full name and phone number (for contact and verification only); listings require admin approval before going live, and are automatically checked against existing listings to flag possible duplicates.
- Conduct free property viewings for interested students — there is no viewing fee to collect, but a student may optionally send a tip afterward, credited straight to the agent's balance with no Rentora cut.
- Earn an automatically calculated agent fee (10% of rent) the moment the student confirms move-in or the auto-release window passes — credited together with the rent amount and any caution fee directly to the agent's Rentora balance.
- Withdraw earnings to a verified bank account through a withdrawal request (minimum ₦3,000 per request); Rentora deducts a 1.3% withdrawal fee from the amount paid out.

For Property Owners

- Owners are not platform users and are not paid through Rentora — an agent adds the owner's full name and phone number when listing a property, purely for contact and verification purposes. Rentora never collects or stores an owner's bank or payout details.
- When a tenant's rent payment is released, the full amount — rent, agent fee, and any caution fee — is credited to the listing agent's Rentora balance. Settling with the property owner is handled directly between the agent and the owner, the same way it already works offline; Rentora's role is to verify the agent, hold the funds safely, and only release them once a genuine move-in has been confirmed.

For Rentora (the Platform)

- Earns from two sources only: the service fee added on top of every rent payment, and a 1.3% fee on every agent withdrawal — never a percentage of rent, agent fee, or tips.
- Reviews and approves every agent and every listing before it's public, acting as the trust layer between students and agents.
- Holds rent in escrow, releases the full amount to the agent once move-in is confirmed, and resolves disputes through an admin panel if something goes wrong.

Business Model

Rentora earns revenue from two points in the flow of money through the platform: a service fee on rent, and a fee on agent withdrawals. It never takes a cut of rent, agent fee, caution fee, or agent tips. Property viewings are entirely free — Rentora charges no viewing fee, and an agent's only viewing-related earning is an optional tip sent directly by the student. Rentora's income comes only from fees layered on top of a transaction or a payout, never from splitting what an agent has earned.

Revenue Stream	How It Works	Platform Share
Rent Escrow	Rentora holds the rent, the agent fee, any caution fee, and a service fee until move-in is confirmed.	Service fee only — the rest is credited to the agent
Withdrawal Fee	Charged when an agent cashes out their balance to their bank account.	1.3% of each withdrawal
Property Viewings	Free for the student to request; no fee is charged to anyone. The agent may receive an optional tip.	No revenue to Rentora

Worked Example — Rent Escrow

To make the rent escrow model concrete, here is how a single transaction flows for a property renting at ₦150,000/year (assuming no caution fee on this listing). The agent fee is always 10% of rent, calculated automatically — agents no longer enter it manually. Using the current default 5% service fee:

- Rent: **₦150,000**
- Agent fee (10% of rent, auto-calculated): **₦15,000**
- Service fee (5% of rent + agent fee, i.e. 5% of ₦165,000): **₦8,250**
- Total charged to the student at checkout: **₦173,250**

Rentora holds the full ₦173,250 in escrow. When the student confirms move-in — or after the auto-release window elapses with no response — the full ₦165,000 (rent + agent fee) is credited to the agent's Rentora balance, and Rentora retains the ₦8,250 service fee. If the listing carries a caution fee, that amount is held and released the same way, untouched by Rentora. Paying the property owner their share is then the agent's responsibility, handled directly between agent and owner, outside the platform.

Worked Example — Agent Withdrawal

Say that same agent has ₦15,000 sitting in their Rentora balance (their agent fee from the release above) and requests a withdrawal to their bank account. Withdrawals have a ₦3,000 minimum per request — well below this balance, so it can be withdrawn in a single request:

- Withdrawal requested: **₦15,000**
- Withdrawal fee (1.3%): **₦195**
- Agent receives: **₦14,805**

This gives Rentora recurring, transaction-linked revenue rather than a flat listing fee — it earns from the rent service fee and the withdrawal fee, never from splitting rent, agent fee, or tips. The platform only earns when a real transaction or payout actually happens, which keeps incentives aligned with genuinely helping students find housing rather than accumulating listings.

Trust & Safety Mechanics

- Every agent is manually verified (ID, selfie, signed agreement, bank details) before they can list a property.
- Every listing is reviewed and approved by an admin before it's publicly visible — and re-reviewed automatically if the agent edits it afterward.

- New and edited listings are automatically checked against existing ones for similar title, location, and price, flagging possible duplicates so two agents can't post the same house without an admin noticing.
- Rent and agent fees are held in escrow rather than paid out the moment a student pays, removing the single biggest point of risk in an informal rental transaction.
- A property is automatically and permanently reserved the moment a renter's payment is confirmed (held) — not only after move-in — so a second renter can't pay for the same listing while another payment is pending. Once a property is taken, it stays taken for good; it cannot be reopened or relisted from the dashboard by anyone, including the agent.
- If a student doesn't confirm move-in, held funds auto-release to the agent after a configurable window, so a non-responsive student can't indefinitely block a legitimate agent from being paid.
- Changes to an agent's own payout bank details go through a separate admin approval workflow, preventing an agent from silently rerouting where their earnings are paid.
- All data access is governed by row-level security at the database layer, so users can only see and act on data relevant to their own role — student, agent, or admin.

Technology

Rentora is built on a modern, production-grade stack chosen for speed of iteration and reliability:

- **Frontend** — React 19 single-page application, styled with Tailwind CSS and shadcn/ui components.
- **Backend & Database** — Supabase (PostgreSQL) for the database, authentication, and row-level security policies enforcing who can see and change what.
- **Payments** — Flutterwave for processing rent payments and optional agent tips securely.
- **Hosting** — Vercel, with continuous deployment from GitHub on every update.

Market

LAUTECH is a large public university in Ogbomosho, Oyo State, with a substantial off-campus student population that needs to secure housing every academic session. Off-campus accommodation is currently sourced almost entirely offline, through informal, unverified channels — a clear opening for a structured, trustworthy digital alternative.

Rentora's model — verification, escrow, admin oversight — is directly portable to other Nigerian university towns with the same informal-housing dynamic, without needing a fundamentally different product.

What's Next

- Deepen the trust layer — e.g. review/rating history for agents, and admin tooling for faster dispute resolution on held rent payments.
- Give agents clearer visibility into rent payments still held in escrow, not just funds already released to their balance.
- Expand from LAUTECH to additional Nigerian university towns using the same verified-agent, escrow-backed model.
- Strengthen SEO and organic discovery so more students find Rentora directly rather than through word of mouth alone.

Contact

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Live at: rentora.com.ng